



Xiaomi slows down

Xiaomi recorded its slowest-ever quarterly growth in revenue as the company hits sales lull. <https://digit.in/dec19-34>



Pixel astrophotography

Google has explained exactly how their astrophotography feature works on the new Pixel devices. <https://digit.in/dec19-35>

Skullcandy Crusher ANC

Too many misses make these cans severely overpriced

Skullcandy's claim to fame has been their bass-forward headphones offered at a relatively affordable price point. While the former point still holds true with the new Skullcandy Crusher ANC headphones, the latter is no longer accurate since these cans, priced at ₹24,999, come close or match the price tag attached with other big-brand wireless ANC headphones. Let's find out how they stack up.

Build and design

These circum-aural (over-ear) headphones sport an eggshell-like finish with minimal design flourishes. The red coloured variant that we got did, however, turn some eyeballs, solely due to the atypical colour. Largely made up of plastic, the headphones, however, do not feel flimsy. Adorned with plush memory foam, the Skullcandy Crusher ANC fit comfortably stay that way even after hours of usage.

Controls

There are 3 physical buttons which have various functions including pause/play, volume, skip/previous track and activating voice assistant. The headphones also feature ambient mode to listen to your surroundings. To turn it on, place your palm on the left earcup for three seconds and repeat the process to revert to normal. The left earcup also houses the sensory bass slider (more on that later). The slider is large and easy-to-access.

Features

One of the more unique features that the Skullcandy Crusher ANC headphones sport is personalised sound via their accompanying app. This is useful for those who are hard-of-hearing. To achieve this hyper-personalisation, you will need to pair your headphones to the accompanying Skullcandy app and complete the listening test. Unfortunately, the app is rendered utterly useless after this sound



customisation, since this is the only feature it offers. Another headlining feature is Sensory Bass. Not only do you hear Skullcandy's bass-accentuating sound but you also feel it. The headphones employ four drivers to deliver thumping bass response. The level can be controlled via the sensory bass slider.

You also get ANC (cue, the name) and Ambient Mode. Additionally, you have Bluetooth 5.0 for wireless connectivity. Alas, the connectivity is somewhat of an issue on these cans which lags and skips aplenty. Coming to battery life, Skullcandy estimates it to be around 24 hours with ANC turned on, and there's Rapid Charge which gives you four hours by charging the cans for a mere ten minutes.

Performance

The Skullcandy Crusher ANC seem to exhibit a dual personality. Turn the sensory bass adjuster all the way down and you will have a pair of headphones that sound relatively balanced, however, turn it up around 20-30 per cent of the way and you will actually 'feel' the bass and also hear distinctly ramped up bass response. Tracks such as *Uptown Funk* by *Bruno Mars* and *Mark Ronson* feature bass beats with adequate thump and vitality. We enjoyed Sensory Bass at 30

per cent. Anything above that destroys the details and the bass sounds muddled. The highs are reproduced decently, however, the mids and vocals sound quite recessed and veiled over by the thumpy bass. However, in *Adele's Skyfall*, the vocals are well-preserved due to the lack of bass instruments overall.

Unfortunately, the ANC is mediocre, if not substandard. The noise-cancelling circuitry does a fairly decent job with low-frequency rumble or sounds, but mids and highs are not cancelled out efficiently at all and fall

prey to the annoying hiss which is heard on ANC headphones with unrefined circuitry. Battery life is decent. Skullcandy rates the battery life at 24 hours with ANC turned on, we got around 21 hours with ANC

on our review unit. Call quality is stellar on these headphones though.

Bottomline

Skullcandy is competing with the likes of flagship wireless headphones from brands such as Sony, Bose, and Jabra, which cost about the same or slightly more. This price tag calls for legitimate quality over gimmicks and the ANC and sensory bass (at more than 30 percent) definitely feel like gimmicks. If you are intrigued by the idea of haptic bass feedback and mostly need ANC to mask low frequencies, then these headphones might be the ones for you. If not, you will find other capable ANC wireless headphones at this price point or tad more.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

HEADPHONE TYPE: Over-Ear | CONNECTION TYPE: Bluetooth 5.0 | IMPEDANCE: 32 Ohms ±15% | DRIVER DIAMETER: 40mm | THD: <1% @ 1K | SOUND PRESSURE LEVEL: 105 dB @ 1 KHz | FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 20Hz - 20KHz | WEIGHT: 308.66g | RANGE: 30 feet | BATTERY LIFE: 24 hours

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